Ancient Grudges and Hokey Religions

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Mature

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F/F, F/M

Fandoms:
Star Wars - All Media Types, The Mandalorian (TV), She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Catra & Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Razz (She-Ra)

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by Rest_at_the_Bonfire

Summary

The Outer Rim is, generally speaking, where you go to lose yourself. Pick a backwater world and just disappear. Empire, Republic, doesn't matter. None of them really care about what goes on out there. A great place to go when you don't want to be found.

Unless, of course, you're getting paid to go looking.

Notes

You ever have one of those ideas that you can't get out of your head until you write it down, so you write maybe a sentence and then hope that's enough, but then it ends up being a lot more than you thought it would be?

Yeah, uh, me neither.

See the end of the work for more notes

Arrival

Chapter Summary

Entrapta makes a friend. Catra goes a-hunting.

If a ship that looked like *that* had landed on any of the core worlds, the mechanic mused, it probably would have immediately been impounded and sold for scrap to ensure that the property values of the surrounding city blocks did not plummet. It looked like someone had bolted the cockpit of a TIE fighter onto the front end of a shipping container and strapped a hyperdrive engine to the top. How it managed to have any control once in atmosphere, he couldn't figure.

But the question fascinated him.

The mechanic straightened up as a hatch on the side rolled up – rolled up, like a garage door, he marveled – and a short stairway lowered to the ground. He wiped his hands on a rag and adopted the general air of someone who knows his services are going to be needed and knows exactly how much that expertise is worth.

Not that he expected whoever was flying around in *that* would have much in the way of cred to make it worth his while. Maybe enough for fuel.

Maybe enough for *some* fuel, anyway.

First to emerge was a Twi'lek, her skin a vibrant purple, dressed in what looked to be a pair of tan overalls and a shirt that might have, at some point in the history of the galaxy, been white, but was now covered in grease stains and goodness knows what else. A welder's mask was perched on her head, but currently was up so that her face was visible. She looked frazzled but enthusiastic.

Probably was working to keep the ship together right up to the ship landing, the mechanic thought.

Second out of the ship was – nope.

Nope.

Not gonna acknowledge this.

Not going to look at the red plate armor, of indeterminate make. Not plasteel, that's for certain. Too much *heft* to it. Certainly not going to observe the red helmet with a black visor shaped like a T – if T were a letter in the galactic alphabet – nor the black cloak flung over one shoulder. Not going to think about the long rifle slung over the shoulder, or the blaster pistol slung low on the hip.

He was definitely not going to acknowledge the tail, or the fact that the helmet had clearly been made to accommodate the ears, nope, not even a little bit.

He was so incredibly not acknowledging it that when the Twi'lek bounded up enthusiastically and nearly shouted "HI!" he almost fell over backwards.

"Ooh, sorry, was that too much? Maybe that was too much." She stepped back with a look of mild concern. "I don't have a lot of practice interacting with humans."

"No, no it's uh… nope." The mechanic hastily composed himself. "It's fine. What can I do for you?"

"Oh good!" She gave a sigh of relief. "If I couldn't manage this, I'd have to ask *her* to help me and," she leaned in conspiratorially and said in a low voice, "She's not really a people person."

"Uh, nope, no need to bring her into this at all." His eyes widened. "Not… at… all."

She fished around in one of her pockets and brought out a tattered list. "What kind of spare parts do you have, and can I have them?" She scrunched up her face, as if she were trying to remember something important. "OH! And fuel, I guess. You've got fuel, right?"

The mechanic turned to look behind him at the large sign that proclaimed *Bow's Gas and Repair* and back at the Twi'lek. "Yeah. Yeah, I've got fuel, too." He held out a hand. "Can I see your list?"

"Hm? What list?"

The mechanic raised an eyebrow. "The list you've got, the one with the parts you need?" He gave a friendly smile, relaxing a little as he watched the figure in red head out onto the main street. "I gotta know what I'm looking for, so I know what I have and, y'know, what it'll cost ya."

"Oh, right! Right." She handed over the paper. "You wouldn't believe how much I had to do just to get here."

"No, I think I might," the mechanic replied, looking past her at the ship before turning to the list. His eyebrows shot up at the list of components. "Some of this is uh, I don't know if I have some of this. I don't think anyone outside of maybe the Imperial military has some of this." He rubbed his chin thoughtfully. "Although…"

"Is it too much? I tried to keep the list down to things I only absolutely needed." The Twi'lek frowned.

"It's not too much," the mechanic hastily responded, "It's just a lot. You looking to replace most of the ship?"

The Twi'lek beamed. "Not replace, *augment*. Redundant systems, improved efficiency, and maybe some *experimental configurations.*" She appeared to be vibrating with excitement. "And all according to my own designs!"

"Wait, wait, wait." The mechanic could feel his heart rate increasing. "You built that ship yourself?"

"Sure did! The last one, well, I didn't build it and it was a real problem and I guess technically isn't really a ship anymore, but luckily we landed in kind of a – a ship graveyard and I put Darla together myself." She practically *glowed* with pride.

"Your ship's name is *Darla*?"

"Well, technically I got the name from a salvaged bulkhead that apparently was in section D4-1LA of I think some kind of Imperial cruiser, but Darla is way easier to say, so it's Darla."

"Sure, that makes sense." The mechanic shrugged. "As much sense as building a ship out of parts you found in a scrapyard that can make a hyperspace jump." He paused. "It uh, it can do that, right? I saw the engine on top and kind of assumed."

"Oh, good guess!" The Twi'lek sounded entirely sincere. "We made one jump anyway, but I need to make sure that the next one doesn't almost tear the ship in half." She gave a giggle that fell somewhere endearing and insane. "I spent a lot of time fixing the hull so we could survive re-entry." A frown. "And then Ca—uh, my partner told me that I had to make sure it wouldn't fall apart the next time or she'd make me space-walk to the nearest station." She grinned brightly. "I don't think she meant it, but I want it to work anyway."

The mechanic made absolutely sure to ignore the partial name. "Well, like I said, some of these parts are really hard to find outside of a military supply line but if you've got the coin for it, I know some people who might be able to work around that. Happy to sell you what I've got on hand, though."

"That'll be fine!" The Twi'lek held out a hand to shake. "I think we're on kind of a tight schedule so let's stick with what you've got on hand for now. I'm Entrapta!"

The mechanic smiled in spite of himself and shook the proffered hand. "Bow. This is my shop. Uh, just out of curiosity, how tight of a schedule?"

Somewhere, in the distance, there was the faintest echo of blaster fire. Entrapta frowned and crossed her arms in annoyance. "Probably tighter than it was a few minutes ago."

*

It was the armor, she told herself. That was why she was at the center of yet another bar fight. Nobody liked the armor. Sure, the right people *respected* it, but nobody really *liked* it. That was their problem, though, not hers. Her problem was currently about two and a half meters tall, covered in scales, and very intent on making sure that *she* was no longer a problem for *him.*

He had tried punching her first, which was a reaction that she could never quite understand. Did people not realize what she was wearing? It could stop blaster fire, vibroblades, you name it, it could probably stop it, and they always tried to *punch* it. Never worked, never turned out well for them. Wasn't very comfortable for her, either, but still, why always a punch? This lizard man – she couldn't recall the proper name for his species at the moment, in the middle of a brawl, go figure – had caught on quicker, though, and elected to next grab and *throw* her across the room. She was currently scrambling back to her feet, giving serious thought as to whether she really needed the extra creds for bringing him in alive.

"Tung, don't make it worse than it already is," she grunted as she dodged out of the way of his charge. "Some nice folks just want to talk to you about some money that you maybe took." Tung, the hulking lizard man, recovered quickly and went low, trying to sweep her feet out from under her with his tail. She leapt over it with surprising grace for someone who'd just been tossed across a room and landed in a crouch, her teeth bared underneath her helmet. Tung reached out to grab her again, but she was ready this time and countered with an uppercut that landed right on the lizard man's jaw. He staggered back in a daze.

The armored woman took the opportunity to press a button on the palm of her gloves. There was a distinct hum and the crackle of electricity as she swiftly pressed her advantage and landed another hit to Tung's center of mass. He doubled over in pain and she wasted no time in bringing both of her hands down on the base of his skull with a loud *crack*. Tung Lashor, wanted for a string of robberies the next system over, went limp and fell to the floor like a bag of laundry. A hush fell over the denizens of the bar.

She ignored them, went about binding the lizard man's arms behind his back and, after a few moments' consideration, wrapping a length of steel cable around his jaws. Last thing she needed was for him to wake up and try to take a bite out of her neck.

With a grunt, she stood back up, stretching her back as she did so. She turned to the bar and pointed at the bartender. "Hey, you got a maglev cart back there?" The bartender, a short, stout human, nodded. "Mind if I borrow it?" He shook his head. "Great, thanks." She fished in one of her pockets and flipped him a coin. He caught it with practiced ease and turned to walk into the back to get the cart.

It was at this point that one of Lashor's crew, a Rodian, shot the armored woman in the head. The blaster bolt made a distinct *ping* as it splashed harmlessly off the armor plating. She didn't even turn around, her gun clearing its holster and shooting behind her in one fluid motion. The Rodian fell back into his chair, a smoking hole in his chest. "I'd ask that nobody else try that," she growled, her voice crackling slightly as it came out of the built-in speakers in the helmet.

There was silence, broken only by someone coughing in what sounded almost like embarrassment. The barkeeper emerged from the back, maglev cart in tow. He walked it over, glancing back at the dead Rodian. The woman in red grunted as she hauled the unconscious Tung Lashor onto the cart. "Thanks again," she said to the barkeep and jerked her head over to the dead Rodian's table. "I'm sure his friends will pay to cover the damage." Her armored visage turned to regard the Twi'lek and Trandoshan who had been sitting with the Rodian. "Right?"

There was another explosion of sound and light, and the Trandoshan slumped onto the floor, two smoking holes in his forehead, his blaster clattering to the ground. The Twi'lek nodded vigorously. "We'll uh, I mean I will be happy to."

"Glad to hear it," she muttered, pushing the maglev cart out the front door and turning down the street, heading in the direction of *Bow's Gas and Repairs*. Hopefully Entrapta had gotten the carbon freezer working again. She was *not* going to deal with a pissed off overgrown lizard during a hyperspace jump, especially not on a ship like Darla.

Not that there were, actually, any ships like Darla. Or named like Darla.

By the time she reached the service station they'd docked at, she could feel the sweat dripping down the fur on her back. Even with the cart, Tung Lashor was heavy and the bar was downhill from *Bow's Gas and Repairs*. She turned into the station and pushed the cart towards her ship. "Entrapta, please tell me you fixed the carbon freezer," she said aloud, assuming that the Twi'lek was within hearing.

Entrapta poked her head out of the hatch of the ship. "First thing I did! Well, maybe the only thing I did." She frowned. "Wait, no, I replaced the broken power couplings and tested the shields and oh, fixed a problem in the hydraulics that I hadn't caught earlier. Did you know we might have not had landing gear? Ha ha ha!" Her head disappeared back into the ship.

"Very reassuring to hear," the woman drawled. "Care to help me with tall, scaly, and irritating?"

The head poked out again and looked down at the unconscious form. "Ooh, he's big. I don't know how much help I'd be but maybe Bow can help?"

"Who. Is. Bow." There was a dangerous edge to the woman's voice.

"That's uh, that's me, sorry," a voice from inside the ship spoke. The woman's tail twitched, showing her irritation. Someone she didn't know was on her ship. She watched as a dark-skinned human emerged from within. "Not my uh, that is I don't usually

help with," his eyes darted to the lizard man and back to the armored woman, "loading… cargo?" He rushed to continue, "But I'll make an exception since uh, you've brought me a lot of business."

Bow would have *sworn* he could actually hear the woman's eyes narrow through her helmet. He watched the helmet look up, then down, and heard a sigh. "Fine. Sure. You want head or tail?"

"Uh, whichever's easier for you, I guess," he muttered.

"I'll take the head, then." The two managed to get Tung Lashor off the cart and into the carbon freezer.

"Thanks," the armored woman said.

"No problem, uh, Miss…?"

"Catra." She looked him up and down. He seemed awfully fit for a mechanic, she thought. Maybe ex-military? She set the thought aside. Not important right now.

"Miss Catra, sure, no problem." He began backing away, heading for the shop's interior. "Well, I should uh, probably see if I can track down some of those parts you're asking for, so uh." He turned and walked briskly inside.

"Bye!" Entrapta called from inside the ship. She popped her head out again. "He's very helpful," she said to Catra.

"Mm. So how long until we can head out?"

"Well…" Entrapta scrunched her face up in the way that someone would if they knew they were about to make someone upset. "Bow says he can get some of the more specialized parts that I wanted to try out, but it will take a while to track them down. That, plus the installation and proper testing, diagnostics—"

"How. Long." Catra's voice was flat. She knew she wasn't going to like the answer.

“Probably a few days? Maybe five?” Entrapta grinned in spite of herself. “It’s gonna be so cool when it’s done, though!”

Catra sighed. Not as soon as she would have liked, but not as bad as she feared. Tung was freezer-fresh anyway, there wasn’t a real hurry. She stepped into the ship and was struck by a sudden thought. “So, how much is all of this going to cost us, anyway?”

Bow, digging through his stockroom, two doors and a ship’s hull away, still snapped his head up as he heard Catra roar, “HOW MUCH?”

Grounded

Chapter Summary

Bow makes a call. Catra broods. Entrapta... well, Entrapta is Entrapta.

Chapter Notes

Well, guess we're doing this now.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow assumed that he had some time before his two clients had sorted out the misunderstanding over the repair bill and took the opportunity to go to the back wall of the stock room. He ran his fingers behind one of the shelving units until they hit a small button. He gave a satisfied grunt and tapped it.

There was a quiet hiss and a puff of air as a hatch popped open on the floor next to him. He descended a ladder, pulling the hatch shut behind him as he went. Fluorescent lights, alerted by his movement, flickered dully to life with a quiet hum. He looked around at the covert workshop and smiled faintly. His eyes passed over a fold-out blaster, a disassembled rifle, and a bowcaster – his personal favorite. They stopped for a moment on a small photograph, before he shook his head. This wasn't the time.

Finally, he found what he was looking for – a compact communicator, quantum entangled. He picked it up and thumbed the transmitter in a pre-determined pattern, then waited. "Come on, come on," he muttered. "I don't have all day."

"Urgh, d'you have any idea what time it is?" The voice on the other end was female, groggy, and very much annoyed.

"No, I don't, because I'm on a completely different planet," Bow replied. "Got a special order in, wondered if you two were still in the business of acquisitions."

“Oh, stars, don’t say it too loud.” The female voice grumbled. “You know how he gets about these things.”

A male voice that sounded much more awake cut in. “Darling, are those the dulcet tones of my good friend Bow, offering us a chance for…”

“Noooo….” The female voice moaned in resignation.

“ADVENTURE!?”

Bow smiled, even though the other side couldn’t see it. “I’ll take that as a yes.”

There was a long, drawn out sigh from the other end before the female voice spoke up again, “Sure, fine. Send us what you need, we’ll let you know how long it’ll take to get.”

“Knew I could count on you,” Bow replied. He fidgeted with the communicator for a few moments before asking, “Have you heard any news about – “

“No, I’m sorry, Bow. We haven’t, still looking.” The voice had a sympathetic tone. “I promise, if we hear anything…”

“Yeah, okay. Thanks, Mer.” Bow disconnected the transmission and leaned against the bench, head down.

He did not go back upstairs for some time.

*

Catra sat in the pilot’s seat of her currently non-functional ship and tried to keep herself calm. She did not enjoy being in any one place for longer than she could help, well aware that her armor made her a target in certain circles. Catra preferred being a moving target to a stationary one. Staying still was for the dead, and she was not. Catra was not afraid of anyone who would knowingly seek out a fight with a Mandalorian, but she saw no reason to make it easy for them. Those fights were not paying

work, merely an occupational hazard. Catra was good at fighting, would even consider saying that she enjoyed it, but she generally did not seek it out.

She stared out of the window. There wasn't much of a view; she had a great view of Bow's store but couldn't really see inside. She could look up, sort of, and see the night sky above, but it was an overcast night, and the sky was therefore uninteresting. Catra leaned back with a sigh, listening to the occasional sounds of tinkering and electrical discharge that told her Entrapta was hard at work either repairing or further destroying the ship.

Entrapta. The Twi'lek was brilliant, of that there was no doubt, but she tended to get carried away when it came to Darla, carried away in the way that meant that Catra would be lucky to profit at all from Tung Lashor's bounty. Not that Catra could stay mad at her for very long. She and Entrapta, they looked out for each other. Catra hadn't been big into the idea of having a crewmate, but after Ord Mantell, well. Entrapta had saved her life, and Catra returned the favor. She trusted Entrapta, and Catra could count the number of people outside of the Clan that she trusted on one hand – one finger, really.

Maybe on two fingers, but – no. She wasn't going to think about that again. Ancient history.

She felt the beginnings of a headache. She always got a headache when she thought about – about her past. Catra shook her head to banish the thought from her mind. Her life before the Clan was irrelevant. They saved her, protected her, gave her a new purpose after she'd lost – well, after she'd lost. Catra felt herself teetering on the precipice of a terrible remembering, tried to turn her thoughts away from the past and back towards her present, planet-bound situation.

At least she'd be bringing the lizard man in alive; turns out she needed the extra credits after all. She idly wondered whether him being cold-blooded meant that he would be more adversely affected by the carbon freezing process, but decided that in the

end, it didn't matter. She was bringing him in alive, the bounty didn't say how functional he had to be when she got him there.

Catra yawned, her head drooping forward. When was the last time she had slept? Had to have been sometime before their nearly disastrous lightspeed jump, there was no way that anyone could have slept through their careening journey through hyperspace. *You should always sleep when you can, no telling when you'll have the opportunity again,* the voice of her mentor floated through her mind. Catra decided to take the advice and let herself drift off to sleep.

*

Entrapta loved machines. She loved putting them together, and taking them apart, and putting them back together so that they worked even better than before. There was no mechanical puzzle she would not solve, no engineering design that she could not improve upon. She knew that her enthusiasm for technology that most sentient beings took for granted was usually misunderstood by those around her, but she also didn't care what they thought. That's why she liked Catra. Catra didn't care what they thought, either. Catra just cared that Entrapta could do things that nobody else could, and Entrapta cared that Catra treated her like she was normal. When she was on Darla, Entrapta was free to be herself, so long as she didn't try to dismantle the hyperdrive mid-jump – which, of course, Entrapta would never do. Maybe take apart the navi-computer and put it back together, but not the actual drive.

She stood up from where she had been welding and looked around. The ship interior was looking much more like a proper ship interior, which is to say that the number of hanging cables and sparking wires had been reduced to nearly none. Entrapta realized that she had done all that she could do for now, and so she left the ship to go looking for Bow. Maybe he had been able to find more of the items on her list.

Ooh, or maybe she could make her own out of whatever else he happened to have in the shop! She might even be able to save

Catra a few credits along the way. She scampered – Entrapta had two ways of moving, one was skipping and the other scampering – to the store and burst through the doors with a "Hey Bow!"

Bow was coming out of the storage room and visibly startled when she spoke. "Whoa! Oh, hey Entrapta."

"Oh! You remembered my name!" Entrapta looked pleased.

"Well, you do make an impression," Bow chuckled. "I only just got confirmation that I can source your more uh, esoteric requests, so it's still going to be a couple of days before I've got the parts, assuming that my source comes through."

"Oh," Entrapta replied. "That's not why I'm here." She paused for a beat, "Do they not come through often?"

*

"You're not authorized to be in this area!" shouted a stormtrooper, pointing his rifle at a gentleman with an impeccably groomed moustache. The gentleman twirled – no, not turned, absolutely not turned, he *twirled* – and his eyes widened.

"Ha HAH!" He dropped to one knee and fired off a shot from a blaster pistol concealed in his voluminous coat. The stormtrooper dropped to the floor like a marionette with its strings cut. "Mermista, darling, I think it's time for us to go!"

"What happened to the plan, Sea Hawk?" a voice crackled over his communicator.

"It lacked style, panache, in short – ADVENTURE!" He sprinted towards the open docking bay doors; a haversack slung over his shoulder. Behind him, the sounds of pursuit grew louder as an alarm began to wail.

"I cannot *believe* I'm in love with you," the voice replied with a sigh. "One minute until extraction."

“Ah, going for the dramatic rescue, I see. I cannot help but approve!” He dove behind a pile of crates as blaster fire began to streak past him. “I shall wait for you with bated breath, my darling!” He could feel the heat of the blaster fire as the stormtroopers began to zero in on his location. He popped up to fire off a few shots of his own before dropping back down. “Ah, jewel of my heart, if you could perhaps hurry? These troopers are most persistent.”

There was a roar of engines as a YT-2400 freighter dropped from the sky and flipped, engines facing the docking bay. A ramp lowered and there she was, green hair blowing in the wash of the engines, a massive repeater rifle in her hands. She fired over Sea Hawk’s head, tearing into the stormtroopers with bolts of boiling blue plasma.

Sea Hawk had never seen anything so beautiful in all his life.

He dove the final distance onto the ramp, as Mermista slammed her hand over the emergency seal. The hatch snapped shut behind him and the ship began to raise into the air. She ran back into the cockpit and gunned the engines as Sea Hawk scrambled to his feet to join her. He sank into the copilot’s chair with a sigh of relief. “Ah, a perfectly executed plan as always.”

Mermista whirled to face him, her dark eyes blazing. “That’s all you have to say for yourself, a perfectly executed plan? You almost got killed!” Without looking away from Sea Hawk, she entered the predetermined course for hyperspace and pulled the throttle down. She grabbed him by the lapels and hauled him bodily up from his seat as the ship launched itself past the speed of light. Her eyes were not so much blazing anymore as they were *smouldering.* “You absolutely reckless idiot.” She pulled him in and fiercely kissed him with – were someone to ask Sea Hawk to describe it – the blazing intensity of a thousand suns.

Time passed. She finally released him and the two sat, catching their breath. “Okay,” Mermista finally managed, her eyes still fiery. “I am going to confirm this course is set properly, and then I am

going to drag you into the cargo hold and tear all of the clothes off of your body."

Sea Hawk's eyes widened. "Ah, Mermista, we do have a perfectly good cabin that we could retire to, you know."

"Yeah, I know," Mermista's voice had dropped to a low growl. "Maybe I'm just looking for *adventure*."

*

Bow considered Entrapta's question for a few moments before replying, "Nah, they've never let me down before."

"Oh, that's great to hear! Anyway, I was wondering…" Entrapta began wandering towards the stock room, chatting with Bow about the various different configurations that she wanted to try and the plans she had to attempt to make the best use of what Bow already had on hand. Bow sighed at first, but was soon caught up in her enthusiasm, and the two continued to bounce ideas off of one another long into the evening.

*

A cloaked figure wandered through a windswept plain, hands extended and brushing against the tips of the taller blades of grass. She walked with no destination in mind, content to wander back and forth in an intricate dance that only she knew. She was looking for something, although she was not yet certain what it was that she sought.

She would know it when she saw it.

The sky overhead was a dark cerulean, smeared with gray clouds that the wind chased across the horizon. The wind whipped her cloak about, revealing the simple white tunic and leggings that she wore underneath. She carried no weapon as she wandered, head turning slightly back and forth as she continued to look.

After an hour of wandering, she finally came to a halt and knelt down. There, before her, was what she had been looking for: a perfect circle of stone laid flat on the ground, covered in runes. She reached out and touched it reverently, then stepped forward and sat down in the center of it, legs crossed.

She closed her eyes, stilled her body, bowed her head, and let her mind wander. The runes on the stone began to glow faintly, though she did not notice. The wind intensified around her but seemed to avoid the stone. She was in an oasis, the air perfectly still.

Sweat began to bead on her forehead as her brow furrowed in concentration. She felt her heartrate increase, her breath coming in short gasps as she struggled with some unseen force. Around her, the wind howled.

Suddenly, her head snapped up. The hood of her cloak fell back, revealing long, golden hair. The woman's eyes flew open; a pair of blazing, steel-blue eyes, staring directly at…

"Catra."

Catra jerked awake and fell out of her chair. She was panting, sweaty, like she'd just run a marathon. She lay on the deck of the ship, staring up at the ceiling. Her mind was racing, trying to make sense of her dream.

It couldn't be.

Catra groaned inwardly. She needed to get off of this planet. Keep moving, onto the next job, the next hunt. Bring honor to her Clan and stay one step ahead of her memories and the one name that she could never bring herself to say.

Adora.

Chapter End Notes

Surprising exactly nobody on this Good Earth, I couldn't manage to leave this one alone for very long. There's a whole lot of space to play in here, and my greatest challenge is going to be having enough patience to not rush into things and actually try pacing this story out properly.

I dunno, we'll see. Thank you as always for reading, and feel free to tell me all of the things that I did wrong in the comments, otherwise I shall assume this is work is a flawless masterpiece.

I spent a good hour on Wookieepedia trying to decide what manner of alien to make Mermista and Sea Hawk, but then I thought... nah. Nothing's going to top Twi'lek Entrapta anyway.

Hangover

Chapter Summary

> An unfamiliar ceiling, a mechanic's thoughts, and a decision to move on.

Chapter Notes

> A little violence in this one. Not a super long fight (for reasons that you'll hopefully see) and not incredibly descriptive, but there's a little bit of a body count in this one towards the end so, y'know, don't be too surprised. Also some uh, bifurcation.
>
> And a decapitation.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She was first aware that she was on her back, arms spread wide, on a floor. She wiggled her fingers experimentally, and decided that the floor was either incredibly dusty, or made of dirt.

Perhaps it was just the ground, then.

The second awareness was one of a burning in her throat. Her tongue stuck to the roof of her mouth; she was thirsty. She opened and closed her mouth slowly, her lips peeling apart. She felt an urge to cough, suppressed it. She needed a drink.

This led to the third and final awareness, which was that it was not dark – her eyes were closed. She slowly cracked an eye to examine her surroundings. A thatched ceiling, unfamiliar. No light but what came through a window on the outside. Definitely a dirt floor.

A thought slowly moved through her mind: *how long have I been laying here?* This was followed immediately by a second thought: *how much longer can I stay here before I have to move?* Her

head lolled to one side and she was confronted by the sight of some kind of fenced area next to her. An animal pen, perhaps? A large hog-like creature wandered into view, snuffling at the ground. Was she in a barn, then?

She turned her mind towards an attempted reconstruction of the previous night's activities. There had been a bar, that much was certain. And drinks, and a pleasant burning sensation in her throat, and more drinks, and then what she would have sworn up and down was friendly conversation, but apparently her view was not shared by the other denizens.

A fistfight! *Ah*, she thought, *that explains the headache.* She brought a hand up to inspect her face, feeling for the bumps and bruises she was sure were there. Her search was rewarded by the tacky feeling of drying blood on her forehead and the distinct feeling of a swollen eye.

You should see the other guy, a voice in her head chirped. She turned her mind back to the evening. After the fight – pretty sure she won – she remembered running from someone. A sore loser, most likely. The sounds of gunfire and a stumbling escape into a barn.

She looked down at her dirty grey tunic and was surprised to find that it was redder than she remembered and there was a hole in it that she could have sworn wasn't there before. She reached down and stuck her finger in the hole and winced.

Not just her shirt, she decided. Someone had shot her. Inconvenient. A blaster bolt, she figured since she'd clearly not bled out overnight. Blaster fire was convenient that way, cauterizing the wound for her. Unfortunately, it meant that she'd have to leave town now. When the locals started shooting, it was time to move on.

She must have passed out from the pain, and whoever had shot her hadn't been *that* angry, or they'd have probably come to finish the job. Then there was a dream, or at least she thought there

had been a dream. Something about a field, and a stone, and a pair of mismatched eyes, one a brilliant amber and the other a dazzling sapphire.

She let herself fall back to the ground with a thud and immediately regretted her decision as pain lanced through her abdomen from the impact. She groaned. Definitely time to move on. Or time to just stay where she was and not move for a while. It was a tempting thought, and she took a few moments to wrestle with the choice.

The sound of heavy footfalls appeared to make the decision for her. She rolled to her stomach and scrambled to her feet, biting off a cry of pain before it could give her away. She looked around at the ground and saw that she had managed to at least flee with her backpack and cloak. She threw the cloak around her shoulders, grabbed the pack off of the ground, and headed in the opposite direction of the footsteps. She slipped out of a side door and was gone.

*

Entrapta awoke in unfamiliar territory. She was laying on a workbench, but it wasn't *her* workbench. It was, however, surprisingly comfortable and warm. Someone had covered her with a blanket at some point, she guessed. She rolled off the bench and onto her feet and looked around. Ah, she was in Bow's shop. The workbench was his! The half-built power couplings were probably hers, though. She was trying to double their maximum threshold so that they'd stand up to the frankly dangerous amount of energy she planned on passing through them and must have drifted off while contemplating a solution.

That happened, sometimes, because Entrapta often forgot to sleep.

She stretched her arms above her head, arching her back to rid herself of the soreness that comes from sleeping on workbenches, and wondered if it had been Bow who had given her the blanket.

It did not seem like a very Catra thing to do, she reasoned, and Bow seemed to be a helpful sort of person. He liked machines, and Entrapta liked machines, and so she was inclined to like Bow as well.

Entrapta made her way out of the shop and headed towards her ship, half-completed couplings slung over her shoulder. She could finish the modifications there. She could also check on Catra while she was at it because Entrapta worried about Catra sometimes. Catra often told her that all she needed in life was the Clan and the hunt. Entrapta knew that to be an absolute lie, but she did not ever challenge Catra on the point. She was perceptive enough to know something was missing, and wise enough to know that she would not be able to solve the problem for Catra. Regardless, she was determined to stay with Catra and help her in whatever way she was able. Luckily, Catra mostly appeared to just need someone to fix stuff, and Entrapta was extremely good at fixing stuff.

She found Catra pacing back and forth inside Darla. Entrapta decided that Catra looked agitated, from the way she was pacing with a nervous energy to the way that her tail was thrashing back and forth behind her. The red helmet, of course, gave nothing away as to her expression. Entrapta knew by this time that the best thing that she could do was distract Catra with something else.

"Hey, Catra!" Catra stopped her pacing and looked towards Entrapta, who continued, "I was talking with Bow earlier and he said that his contacts had managed to get what we were looking for. They should be arriving in the next day or so." She smiled as she saw some of the tension drop out of Catra's stance. Good.

"Finally," Catra sighed. "We need to get off this rock and back on the hunt. Lizard's not gonna keep forever."

"Well certainly not forever, but theoretically he could be kept in hibernation for at least a galactic standard month before the risk of any permanent damage from the process."

“Well, then perhaps I just want to get him off my ship and move on to the next job.” Catra shook her head. Of course Entrapta would take her words literally.

Their conversation was interrupted by the sound of a ship approaching. Catra poked her head out of the hatch to try and get a glimpse of whatever it was flying overhead. She caught sight of Bow jogging out of his shop. “Hey, Catra! Seems like you’re in luck, my contacts are running ahead of schedule.” He stopped. “I’m heading down to the docking bay to meet them; you’re welcome to come along if you’d like a change in scenery.”

Catra paused, considering her options. On the one hand, she had no real interest in meeting anyone that she did not need to meet. On the other, she was tired of staying in one place and it might be helpful for her to make a connection with someone who was able to procure military-grade hardware with such short notice. Her boredom and the prospect of such a contact won out, and she gave a shrug. “Sure, let’s go see who these friends of yours are.”

*

The previous evening had been a mistake, she knew. She shouldn’t have let her guard down, shouldn’t have allowed herself to relax – shouldn’t have had that much to drink, a dull headache reminded her. She definitely shouldn’t have gotten into a fight. She had managed to drink some water, eat an emergency ration bar that she’d been carrying around, but the blaster burn on her torso still hurt.

More importantly, she had been *noticed*. Word must have gotten out about the previous evening, and some conclusions must have been drawn, and that was how she now found herself walking towards the outskirts of town being pursued by a group of about six rough-looking locals. She’d ignored them when they’d started following her, trying to play for time as she drew them out of the town center. She didn’t need an entire audience for what was probably going to happen next.

They were a motely crew, she thought. A Rodian, two Trandoshans, a Weequay, and a couple humans, all armed with a hodgepodge of weaponry one might expect to find in a frontier town. Once she judged herself to be far enough from the town, she slowed to a halt and turned to regard the group. They fanned out and surrounded her, and she nearly rolled her eyes at the predictability of it all. She kept her hood up and rolled her shoulders, feeling her muscles loosen. "Good morning, gentlemen," she said. "Was there something you needed?"

One of the humans, a scruffy-looking large fellow who was holding some kind of stun baton, spoke up. "Matter of fact, we're here on behalf of our friend, Griff." The woman nodded and gave a gesture that conveyed, *please continue*. The man spoke again, "See, you roughed our friend Griff up pretty bad last night, and well, he's our friend."

"Yes, you mentioned." The woman let her arms fall to her sides and slowly exhaled. "Please extend my heartfelt apologies for the misunderstanding last evening to your friend, once he wakes up."

"Sure, sure," the Rodian spoke up now. "Only, well, we got to talking after you ran off. See, I thought you seemed kinda familiar." He gave a weird chuckle. "And that didn't make sense, because you'd only just shown up." He tapped his head, "but I've got a real good memory for faces."

"Perhaps I just have one of those faces," the woman replied.

"Nah, see, it took me a little while to remember where I'd seen you, but then it hit me." The Rodian's (weird little) mouth curled into what probably passed for a smile to his species. "Saw this bounty notice hanging in the old Imperial outpost, pretty good payout for bringing in some supposed Jedi who looks an awful lot like you." He shrugged and gestured with his blaster pistol. "Figured if we rounded you up, maybe that reward money would go towards easing ol' Griff's discomfort."

The woman's face hardened; her mouth set into a thin line. "Careful, now. Throwing around accusations like that could get someone into trouble. I'm no Jedi."

"Well, that's a relief," the second man, tall and thin, spoke up. "We can still get that reward money, and we don't have to fight a Jedi to do it." The group laughed together at the joke. "Now, you can come quietly, or you can come in pieces." He hefted an axe meaningfully.

"I am going to ignore the fact that you've accused me of being a Jedi and the fact that you're harassing me right now." The woman shrugged, and her cloak fluttered to the ground, revealing her golden hair and simple, homespun clothing. Hanging from the belt around her waist was a short metal cylinder. "You all can walk away, and we'll forget this little misunderstanding."

"How generous," the Rodian chirped. "You'll forgive us if we don't take you up on your offer." He nodded to his companions, and they began to slowly advance, closing the circle tighter around her.

The woman closed her eyes and sighed, and it was not a sigh of frustration, or of relief, or even of exhaustion, though she was tired. It was a sigh of pure joy.

Remember, Adora, one who truly masters the art of the sword is one who strikes without thought of action.

Her master's words. Mara's words. In one fluid movement she had ignited her lightsaber with a brilliant golden flash and separated the Rodian's head from his body. Before his head had hit the ground, she had dropped to a crouch and cut the two Trandoshans off at the waist. She pirouetted neatly and sliced the Weequay neatly in two, longways, before the remaining humans even registered what had happened.

The Rodian's head hit the ground with a wet thud and at the sound she flipped backwards, landing behind the two humans

who were dead before they even had time to turn around. Adora’s lightsaber was extinguished and back on her hip before the last body hit the ground, kicking up a cloud of dust. She stepped over the corpses and retrieved her cloak and haversack. As the adrenaline slowly bled from her system, Adora grimaced.

So much for staying on this planet. If she were being recognized by locals, it wasn’t going to be long before word got out and she’d be dealing with more than just whatever passed for local muscle around these parts. Time to move on.

Adora began to walk again, alone. It was best that she remained alone. She could not allow herself to become attached again. Not after what happened the last time. She had lost her master, lost her home, and lost her best friend. It had nearly broken her, sent her down a dark and self-destructive path. No, better to continue to wander, to lose herself in the Outer Rim.

She would not fall to the Dark Side.

Not again.

Chapter End Notes

> So, we jump between planets again in this chapter and man I'm going to have to start putting names on these planets to keep things straight, aren't I? We'll see how long I can push it.
>
> Hey, Adora...
>
> Seek Heaven through Violence, girl.

Pie

Chapter Summary

In which parts are exchanged and pie is procured.

Chapter Notes

Aw yeah, we're back. We're back, and we didn't even take a detour to a completely unrelated noir-adjacent fic that has been slowly brewing in my brain.

Nope, we're here instead. Star Wars and She-Ra, baby!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had a problem. The problem was roughly six feet tall with roguish charm – that very much did not work on Catra, but apparently worked on some people – and currently owner of the specialty parts that Entrapta had asked Bow to provide. The problem was currently hiding behind Mermista and admonishing Bow about the company that he was keeping.

"Did you not know that she is the very bounty hunter that delivered me to those gangsters on Nar Shaddaa? Into the very clutches of my enemies!"

Catra shrugged. "It was the job. And they clearly didn't do a good job of keeping you around." She turned to Bow. "Let's just get this over with and go our separate ways."

"Okay, Sea Hawk, I'm sure we can all be professional about this, right?" Bow started walking up the boarding ramp and beckoned Catra to follow.

"Oh no, she is not coming on my ship," Mermista stated flatly, glaring at Catra. "Do you have any idea what I had to do to get him back from the Hutts?"

“No, and I don’t particularly care to know.” Catra was getting annoyed. Sometimes the galaxy didn’t feel nearly as big as it should. “Nobody’s paying me to bring him back, so there’s no problem.” She leaned against one of the hydraulic arms that raised and lowered the ramp. “I’ll stay down here if it makes you feel better.”

“It does!” Sea Hawk shouted over his shoulder as he walked back into the depths of the ship, Mermista and Bow following. Bow visibly relaxed at Catra’s offer to remain outside; he wasn’t sure that he’d be able to stop Mermista if she decided to start a fight.

“So uh, hope it wasn’t too much trouble getting these parts,” he began, hoping to take their minds off of their history with Catra. Sea Hawk gave a booming laugh.

“Ah, no trouble at all! Only the clarion call of ADVENTURE!”

“Would have been less trouble if you’d stuck to the plan,” Mermista grumbled. Sea Hawk gave her his most winning smile.

“I was able to improvise because I knew that you had my back, my sensual siren of the stars.” Mermista turned away to hide a smile, her face turning a darker shade. Sea Hawk continued, “Besides, any chance to cause trouble for our Imperial interlopers is worth taking!” Bow raised an eyebrow and glanced at Mermista before turning back to Sea Hawk.

“Imperials, huh? So, these parts fell off the back of a supply truck?”

“Nothing so banal as that, my dear fellow. Where’s the adventure in that? No, good sir Bow, I struck at the very heart of an Imperial facility! What once was for a TIE fighter is now for you.” He struck a pose. “We go above and beyond for our favorite customer!” Mermista groaned. Bow smiled at Sea Hawk, though his brow wrinkled with concern.

“The Empire’s not going to uh, come looking for this stuff, are they?”

"Uh, we're *professionals*, Bow," Mermista replied. "I made sure that everything was clean while we were in transit. No tracking devices, no serial numbers." She crossed her arms. "I'm almost offended you asked."

"Hey, look, you saw who these parts are for." Bow held up his hands in a placating gesture. "Last thing I need is an angry Mandalorian coming back to me because their ship got impounded for having stolen tech." His hand drifted back to rub his neck. "Speaking of, if I'd known your uh, history I wouldn't have put you in this position."

"Think nothing of it," Sea Hawk laughed. "You couldn't have known anyway, and as much as it pains me to agree with my former jailer, it was never anything personal." He hefted a large duffel bag. "And this was far too much fun getting for me to stay angry."

"You and I have very different ideas about what fun means," Bow chuckled, taking the bag and slinging it over his shoulder. "Thanks again, you two," he called over his shoulder, heading down the boarding ramp.

"Keep paying us, we'll keep delivering the goods," Mermista replied with a smirk. Her face softened. "And we'll keep an eye out for your lady friend, as well." Bow stopped halfway down the ramp and turned his head, a bittersweet expression on his face.

"Thanks, Mer."

Catra had moved away from the ship and was sitting on a cargo container when Bow stepped off the ship. She jumped down and walked towards him. "So, everything set?"

"Yeah," Bow responded, handing her the bag. "Job done."

"Great." Catra hefted the bag across her shoulder and began walking back to the repair shop. Bow followed after her, deep in thought. Finally, he appeared to come to a decision and spoke up.

“Hey, Catra?”

Catra did not stop walking, nor turn her head. “What is it, more complications?”

“No, no,” Bow shook his head as he increased his pace so that he was walking next to her. “I was just wondering…”

“Spit it out,” Catra sighed, still not breaking stride.

“What exactly did Sea Hawk do to get on the wrong side of the Hutt Cartel?”

“Well, you know those giant pleasure barges they like to sail around on whatever planet they’re on?” Catra turned her head to look at Bow, who nodded. “Apparently Sea Hawk managed to set one on fire.”

“You mean he blew it up?” Bow’s eyes widened a little.

“No, I mean he set it on fire,” Catra responded. “Damndest thing, nobody could figure out how he managed it, but none of the fire suppression systems triggered and the whole thing just burned until it was a bare frame and an engine.” Bow gave a low whistle.

“That’s actually pretty impressive,” he muttered.

“Yeah, well, Hutts didn’t see it that way, so they contacted the Guild and the Guild contacted me and I was paid pretty well for hauling him back to Nar Shaddaa to chat with the Hutts.” She shrugged. “End of story. Not my most impressive work, Sea Hawk isn’t exactly dangerous.”

“Not unless you’re a ship, I guess.”

Catra was glad that nobody could see the grin on her face underneath her helmet. She had a reputation to maintain, after all.

*

Adora needed a mask. Apparently, her encounter with the local would-be bounty hunters had cause something of a stir, and now there were pictures of her face just about everywhere. She had dealt with two more groups of self-appointed militia since then, and the body count was getting high enough that whoever passed for the local government might be inclined to reach out to the Imperial governor, who would probably be very interested in reports of a potential Jedi on their planet.

What Adora really needed was a way off-planet, but a mask would at least buy her some time while she worked on that particular problem. If nothing else, it would let her walk down a street without being immediately surrounded by a group of whatever passed for local muscle with more greed than brains. Fortunately for her, there was some kind of dust storm sweeping across the plains at the moment, so masks were currently commonplace and wouldn't raise too many eyebrows. Still, she had been spending most days hiding out in a variety of exciting, abandoned dwelling places, run-down factories, and at least one other occasion an old barn, and moved about during the night.

That was how she found herself in what appeared to be some kind of old junk shop, rummaging around for an older generation of rebreather that would obscure her face enough that she could move around with a little more freedom. She had not seen the shop owner yet and was hoping that she could keep the interaction to a minimum. It would be just her luck to be recognized by the person she was buying the mask from.

"Ah, I didn't see you there." Adora startled briefly before turning to see the source of the voice: a short, stout old woman with wild grey hair and giant glasses, dressed in light purple robes and a shawl. "Come, come, what are you here for?"

"Oh! Uh, just a rebreather, y'know… the dust storm and all." Adora gestured towards the door. The old woman nodded, clucking her tongue.

“You’ve come to the right place, dearie. I know just the thing, eh?” She looked around the shop with an air of confusion. “Or maybe I know the thing, but not where it is.” She shuffled over to a box and began rummaging through it. “Pah, no, not here, not there.” She moved onto a second box and repeated the process, pulling things out and inspecting them before putting them back and muttering to herself again. Adora coughed politely.

“Do you need some help?”

The old woman’s head shot up and she smiled. “Ah, of course. Help! Help will know where it is.” She pointed a finger at Adora. “You wait here, miss Adora, and maybe cover your face. Too pretty to go unseen, yes?” Adora opened and closed her mouth in shock, trying and failing to come up with a response. The old woman shook her head with a smile. “Little girl, you are not a fish. Stop acting like one!” She shuffled – or was it skipped? The woman seemed incredibly spry for her apparent age – into the back of the shop, shouting, “Glimmer! Glimmer, help is here.”

“Razz? What are you talking about?” A younger voice responded.

“No questions, come along now!” The old woman – Razz, Adora guessed – returned from the back followed by a young woman with hair that seemed to sparkle and turned from pink to purple, seemingly on a whim. She smiled as she noticed Adora, still looking shocked in the corner.

“Oh, hello.”

“You see?” Razz cackled. “Help is here!” She pointed a bony finger at Glimmer. “You are the help!”

Adora smiled back at the young woman – Glimmer? – and gave a small wave. “Is she always like this?”

Glimmer smiled. “Has been for as long as I’ve known her. So, what am I helping with?”

"Our friend Adora here needs a mask! Too many people are noticing her pretty face and it is tiresome," Razz replied. "I say to her 'wait here, wait here, help will know where the mask is." Glimmer shot a quizzical look at Adora.

"Uh, can you clarify what I'm actually looking for?"

Adora managed to control her reaction to this old woman using her name *again* long enough to respond, "I'm just looking for a rebreather to filter the dust out from the storm and *how do you know my name?"* Well, she almost managed to control her reaction.

Razz waved the question away, replying "Pah! Your name is as plain as anything, written right on your face. Just like this one's," she jerked a thumb back at Glimmer. "Only this one, hah, she could not see her name until I told it to her!"

"It's a long story," Glimmer said hurriedly, turning away to rummage through yet another box overflowing with miscellaneous junk. "A rebreather, right?"

"Yeah, I was hoping to get one of those bigger models that covers the whole face, y'know?" Adora shrugged. "Allergies."

Glimmer's eyes narrowed, but she merely said, "Sure, I think we have one around here somewhere," and continued digging. Adora stood uncomfortably in the corner watching as Razz's eyes darted back and forth between her and Glimmer. Razz appeared to be muttering to herself as she did so, and eventually gave a decisive nod, as if she'd just concluded something important.

"All right, that settles it." Adora and Glimmer both looked at Razz, who smiled beatifically. "You will stay with us, Miss Adora, until it is time to go."

"I really don't think that's a good idea," Adora began to say, but Razz cut her off.

“No, no, no need to worry. Nobody looking for Adora will find her if she is with Madame Razz. And Adora has an appointment to keep.”

Glimmer shrugged helplessly. “Sorry, she gets like this sometimes. You’re welcome to stay or go.” She cocked her head to one side. “Although you’re the first person she’s asked to stay since, well, me.”

“Yes, yes,” Razz continued, “Glimmer had to stay, she had to wait for the right time to leave. Otherwise, she wouldn’t remember anything!” She held up a half-mask rebreather triumphantly. “Ah! See, then, you helped after all.”

“But I didn’t –“ Glimmer began.

“Hush, girl! Come, come, it’s late and everyone is hungry. Madame Razz has made pie!” She walked into the back, taking the mask with her. “Hurry, Adora, before the pie gets cold!”

Glimmer turned to Adora, who was still trying to process everything that had just happened. “She’s not wrong, you know. It’s good pie.” Her face scrunched up, as if she were trying to remember something. “And Razz is… she’s got this way about her, you know? Makes you feel safe.” She shrugged and smiled fondly. “I’d have been lost without her.”

Adora was about to make her excuses and leave. She could always find a mask elsewhere, after all. There were other shops, she was sure of it. She almost managed to turn around and head out the door before the hairs on her arms and the back of her neck began to stand up. She suddenly felt a presence, old and kind and powerful, beckoning her to follow Razz. A peace she had not known in ages settled into her soul and she gave a sigh. “Yeah, there’s definitely something about her.” She smiled at Glimmer. “Well, if the pie is good, I suppose I can stay for a little while.”

“Of course you can stay!” Razz’s voice floated out from the back. “Your ship is not here yet. You must be patient! Patient and hungry. For pie!”

Chapter End Notes

Clearly every ongoing story I tell gives me trouble somewhere around chapter three. Or four? I guess this is chapter four. Point is, this one started rocky for me and went through a pretty extensive rewrite and then Madame Razz just SHOWED UP and I did not intend for her to be in this story at all but, well, she's very persuasive, you know? Made a good case for herself.

Look at this, we've found Glimmer! Well, someone's found her, anyway. What's been keeping her, I wonder?

Your comments and kudos drive the burning breath of life within me. Exhale! Exult!

When we come back next time, maybe space travel? SPACE TRAVEL! And a couple new characters that have nothing to do with She-Ra or Star Wars but whom I am deeply fond of will perhaps make an appearance. Fret not, dear reader, they shall integrate into this wild weave with nary a ripple.

But seriously, though, gun to my head I cannot explain how Razz found her way into this story. I think she fits in rather nicely, no?

Contracts.

Chapter Summary

Planets are left and plans are made. A contract is taken.

Chapter Notes

Here it is! I didn't forget about this, or my other currently ongoing tale, but I've not been in the right headspace to get anything done. Hope the wait wasn't too onerous.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The final installation had taken a day longer than Entrapta had originally calculated, but Catra was far too excited to be able to leave the planet to care. Entrapta, however, was perturbed as much as she could be when faced with a miscalculation, which is to say not too perturbed at all. Miscalculations were just opportunities to improve her forecasting, after all, and she would enjoy going through the process over and over in her head to figure out which part of the process she had underestimated.

Catra thought she was crazy for actually enjoying that sort of thing, but also knew that Entrapta's peculiarities were what made her such an excellent mechanic. Not many in the galaxy could build an entirely functional starship from scavenged parts, after all. Even fewer could repair that starship in the middle of a hyperspace jump and keep it from flying apart in the process. If Entrapta wanted to obsess over her calculations, well, Catra would let her, no questions asked, and no judgments made.

"Entrapta, are we good to go?" Catra made her way into the rear of the ship. Entrapta's head popped out of a wall compartment, mask down and looking the wrong way.

"Sure are, Catra! Er, where are you?" She turned her head around to face Catra. "Ah! There you are. We're ready to launch." Catra cocked her head to one side.

“Um, Entrapta? Why are you in the wall?”

“Oh, no reason.” She flipped up her mask and gave a winning smile. “Nothing that will delay our departure, anyway. Not unless something goes *really* wrong, but I would say there’s only about a two percent chance that happens.”

“Right. Very reassuring.” Catra nodded slowly. “Can you wait until we’re off-planet to do… whatever it is?” She headed towards the hatch. “I don’t know about you, but I’m ready to get rid of that hunk of carbonite in the hold and get paid.”

“Oh, speaking of, did you pay Bow yet?” Entrapta wriggled her way out of the compartment and fell to the floor with a thump. This did not appear to bother her in the least.

“Heading out to settle up now,” Catra replied.

“Bow’s nice, Catra. I like him.” Entrapta nodded her head in approval. “Be nice to him!” Catra waved off the comments as she walked out of the ship. Bow was waiting for her just outside. She gave him a nod, then reached for the bag of credits hanging from her belt.

“Pretty sure this’ll cover the rest of what we owe you, plus a little extra for the fuel.” She tossed the bag to Bow, who caught it with ease.

“Pleasure doing business with you. Feel free to stop by if you’re ever in need of repairs again.” Bow gave a friendly smile. Catra gave a short bark of laughter.

“No offense, but that’s great motivation to take better care of the ship.” She turned to leave. “I’ll keep it in mind, though.”

“Hey uh, before you go…” Bow hesitated as Catra turned to face him and he felt the impassive gaze of the helmet. “If you happen to run into a friend of mine out there, maybe let her know I’ve been looking for her?”

“Don’t usually go out of my way to work for free,” Catra responded evenly. “Not likely to just bump into someone out here on the Rim, either.”

“Sure, yeah,” Bow said, rubbing the back of his neck with one hand. “Look, I’m not asking you to go looking, just to maybe drop a word if you happen to stumble across something.”

“Sorry, Bow. Gonna have to find someone else.” Catra made to leave again. Bow hesitated for a moment and then tossed the bag of credits back to Catra. The action caught her off guard, but years of training allowed her to quickly recover and catch it.

“Just… just keep an eye out, okay?” Bow sighed. Catra regarded him curiously.

“Who is this friend of yours that’s worth all the parts in my ship?” Bow fished a data stick out of his pocket and fiddled with it. A small hologram of a young woman’s face appeared.

“Didn’t always run this shop,” Bow replied. “Had a life elsewhere before the Empire rolled in and decided that our planet had something they needed more than we did. Some of us didn’t see it their way, so along came the Imperial war machine.” His face fell. “Got separated in the evac. I know her ship made it off-planet, but lost track of her after that. We were supposed to meet up here after, but…” He sighed again and his voice dropped. “It’s been a year already.”

‘Hm.” Catra thought about blonde hair and blue eyes, of years together brought to a sudden end. She tossed the bag back to Bow. “Keep the credits for now. Just give me the stick and if I happen to run across her, I’ll bring her back.”

“Thanks.” A tension seemed to drop out of Bow’s shoulders, just a little. “Her name’s Glimmer, by the way.”

“All right, Bow. No promises, no contract, but if I happen to run into her, we’ll talk.” She turned and stepped into the ship. “Thanks for the repairs, Bow. Hey, Entrapta! Spin up the engines, time to

go.” The hatch shut behind her. Bow stepped back as the engines roared to life and watched as the ship rose into the air. The ship wobbled, as if unsure whether it actually was within the understood laws of physics to move at all, but after a moment surged confidently skyward and was soon lost to sight.

*

Catra was dreaming. She was reliving the memory of her first hunt. The contract was to bring in a smuggler who had skipped out on a delivery and, so the rumors had told, sold the cargo to a third party at a comfortable profit and seemingly disappeared. It had taken days of chasing rumors around some backwater star system before she had found him in a mining bar on an asteroid, strung out on spice and half-dead. She’d clubbed him over the head and dragged him back to her ship. Most of the locals went out of their way to avoid her and even the more adventurous ones settled for merely shooting her dirty looks. On the trip home, she’d let her guard down and the smuggler had taken advantage and attempted to kill her. They’d fought in the cramped confines of the ship until Catra gave him a solid headbutt with her helmet and he’d crumpled to the ground.

He’d spent the rest of the trip stuffed in a cargo container. Catra smiled in her sleep at the memory. It was a good one.

Entrapta was very much awake, and not at all disassembling important parts of Darla in an attempt to improve on her designs of the various systems and subsystems of the ship. Catra had been very clear that she was not to disassemble the ship mid-hyperspace jump, and Entrapta was determined to abide by this request, even if she were certain she could improve the fuel efficiency by at least 0.7% if she just made a *few adjustments*. She did not make the adjustments. Instead, she wandered towards the cockpit to check on the progress of the hyperspace jump and prepare for the return to sub-light speed. She’d expected to find Catra there, probably dozing in the pilot’s chair or keeping an eye on things but was surprised to find the cockpit unoccupied. That meant that Catra might actually be getting some

sleep. Entrapta smiled at the thought; Catra was almost as bad about getting sleep as Entrapta was, and Entrapta did not spend her days chasing down heavily armed bounties. She settled into the pilot chair and made some adjustments to the course and waited for the notification from the navi-computer to drop out of hyperspace.

*

The planet Nevarro did not have much to recommend itself to the Empire, nor the Republic, and thus had managed to stay clear of most of the galactic-level conflicts that had become distressingly commonplace in the past few galactic standard centuries. There were rumors of some kind of Imperial research facility hidden out in the more inhospitable reaches of the planet, but the Empire did not seem particularly interested in confirming or denying such speculation and kept interactions with the various settlements that dotted the surface of the planet to a minimum. That included the enforcement of any sort of law, and so the Bounty Hunters' Guild had found fertile ground in which to thrive. While the Guild did not keep any sort of official offices in the main settlement, it did keep a list of favored cantinas and dive bars that one could be generally guaranteed to find a representative at, were one so inclined.

And were one looking, one would find a pair of representatives occupying a corner booth – furthest from the front door and with a clear view of all entrances and exits. The one sitting down was dressed in something that could have, at one point, been a military uniform, but no longer bore any insignia of its origin. She wore her violet hair in a long braid that reached down her back, and her violet eyes were currently staring at a datapad that she was manipulating with one hand. A blaster pistol sat on the table in front of her, no effort being made to conceal it.

Her companion was leaning her back against the wall, arms crossed in front of her. She was dressed in a simple white shirt, black pants, and a black jacket over top. She wore armored gloves and had a curious-looking emitter strapped to her right arm. Her

silver hair was pulled into a simple ponytail, and her grey eyes roved around, keeping watch on the various other denizens of the bar. The woman gave the impression of a bodyguard, and one that was likely best left alone. Seemingly satisfied with her most recent sweep of the bar, she turned to regard her companion.

"Hey, Eltnam. Doesn't seem like there's much in the way of business here today. Are you sure we need to remain here?"

The other woman responded without looking up. "Not yet, Ries. We have one more appointment to keep." She continued to work on the datapad. "I calculate our business will conclude within the next thirty minutes."

This appeared to satisfy the taller woman, though she shook her head with a wry grin. "Have I told you it's weird that you talk like that? Everything's always according to calculations with you."

"At least once a day, though today you were slightly late in your observation." The seated woman's eyes flickered up momentarily and a fond smile flashed across her face before she returned to her work. "It appears that our appointment is also slightly late."

"Anything we should be worried about?" Ries shifted her stance slightly in anticipation of trouble.

"No, this delay is well within the predicative model for our client. Ship problems, most likely." Eltnam raised an eyebrow at her companion. "There's no need for that, Ries." She looked towards the entrance of the cantina. "See? She's here."

Catra stepped through the doorway and scanned the crowd for her Guild contact. She spotted the duo and headed towards them with purpose.

"Catra! Always a pleasure to see you," Ries said brightly, although she made no move to offer any other sort of greeting. Catra wondered how someone so imposing could be so cheerful but set the thought aside.

“Ries, Eltnam. What’s the next job?”

Eltnam held up a hand. “Momentarily. What was the outcome of the previous assignment?”

“Nothing worth mentioning,” Catra replied. “Street thug with aspirations, nothing more. Didn’t take much effort.”

“Just time, then?” Eltnam looked at Catra, attempting to read something of her reaction. Catra, of course, did not react at all. Not anywhere that Eltnam would have been able to see, anyway.

“Ship repairs take time. My ship required extensive maintenance before we could leave the planet.” Catra shrugged. “Didn’t make a difference, client was more than happy to wait a few extra days for the delivery.”

“Of course. Dead or alive?”

“Alive, if a bit freezer-burned. Had to put him in carbon freeze so he wouldn’t cause trouble in transit.”

“I assume that he was not in much of a condition to complain, given the alternative.” Eltnam put down the tablet and folded her hands before staring at Catra. “Excellent work, as always.”

Behind her visor, Catra’s eyes narrowed. “You’re buttering me up for something. What is it?”

“Ha! Told you she’d figure it out.” Ries chuckled from the corner. Eltnam did not react.

“I will be frank with you, Catra. This next job is a far cry from hunting down a rowdy street tough.” She tapped a few icons on the datapad and a small hologram of a planet appeared, hovering over the table. “This job comes from the Empire.”

Catra took a step back. “You know I don’t work for them, Eltnam.”

“You and your clan’s dislike for the Galactic Empire is known, yes,” Eltnam replied before leaning forward. “The job, however, requires a level of skill and experience that I simply cannot find elsewhere. Only a Mandalorian will do.”

Catra let out a derisive snort. “What, flattery now? I don’t take Imperial contracts, Eltnam. Find something else.” She shook her head. “If this job requires a Mandalorian, you’ll never find one that will work willingly with the Empire.”

“Normally, I would agree.” Eltnam nodded. “This, however, is a rather unique situation.” She tapped a few more buttons and the hologram’s perspective shifted, zooming down to a high satellite view of a dusty road on the outskirts of a settlement. A half-dozen corpses, most of them missing heads or split in half, came into view. “These images are from about a week ago. The work of one person, so far as I can tell. The target.” She fiddled with the datapad again and the view zoomed away to another overhead view, this time a moving image. Catra watched two well-armed bounty hunters approach a cloaked figure in an alleyway. There was no audio, but she saw the two hunters raise their weapons and gesture threateningly.

The cloaked figure stopped but kept its back to the two. They appeared to converse with the hunters briefly before rolling their shoulders and cracking their neck. The two hunters were now aiming their rifles and appeared to be delivering some sort of ultimatum, and then the cloak figure dropped to one knee, whirling about and extending one hand. A small object flew towards the two hunters before one side exploded into a golden arc of energy and twirled in the air, scything through the two hunters before disappearing and returning to the cloaked figure’s outstretched hand. The entire sequence, from start to finish, had taken less than five seconds.

“As you can see,” Eltnam continued, “the last pair to take this job did not fare well. I did warn them it was beyond their skill.”

“Is that…?” Catra trailed off, eyes fixed on the image of the figure calmly walking away from the scene and disappearing around a corner.

“Analysis of the available data suggests that the target is a Jedi,” Eltnam stated. “We do not have much more to go on; the target appears to have gone to ground on the planet of Takodana.”

“Takodana? Don’t think I’ve heard of the place.”

“It is a bit outside of your normal hunting grounds.” Eltnam made a few more adjustments and a set of coordinates flashed over the image. Catra squinted.

“Middle Rim system, huh.” She shook her head. “My kind aren’t exactly welcome there.”

“This particular planet is as close to the Outer Rim as you can get without being classified as such,” Eltnam replied. “Don’t worry, the scourge of civilization has not touched it any more than it has our lovely surroundings.”

“A Jedi, huh?” Catra scratched her chin under her helmet. “I assume the Empire isn’t keen on having this one brought in alive?”

“Normally you would assume correctly, but the Moff that registered this bounty was at pains to specify that she wanted this Jedi alive. Plans on making an example of the creature, I assume. Public execution.” Eltnam shook her head. “Barbaric.” She continued, “It is my understanding that the Jedi and Mandalorians were once fierce enemies. The honor of facing such an enemy would surely outweigh any grudge against the Empire.”

“In that,” Catra straightened up, “you are correct.” She sighed. “All right, I’ll take the job. I don’t want to deal with any Imperial contacts, though. You broker the deal, and you make the handoff. I deliver to you, not them.” She turned and began to walk away. “Transfer the details to my ship; Entrapta will be there to receive.

I won’t be there for some time, but we’ll be off-planet by tomorrow.”

“Pleasure as always,” Ries said with a grin. She turned to Eltnam. “You look pleased with yourself.”

“All according to my calculations, Ries.” She stood and offered her arm to the taller woman. “Shall we retire for the evening?”

“At your side, of course,” Ries replied, threading their arms together. The pair walked out of the cantina and were soon lost to sight.

*

Entrapta was busy sorting through the data provided by Eltnam when she received one more heavily encrypted message from Catra. It simply read *Gone to visit the family. Back soon.*

Chapter End Notes

> Now we're getting somewhere! Our storylines are converging, finally, and uh wait hang on who are those Guild reps anyway? I'm sure that information is not at all important and will never be explored elsewhere.
>
> Nope.
>
> If I've read one of your ongoing stories, chances are I've posted something about being perfectly content to wait as long as it takes for an update. I say that partially because it's true, partially because none of us are exactly doing this as our day job (unless you are, in which case I am very jealous of you) and partially because it makes me feel better about the fact that my own scheduled output is uh, sporadic, we'll say. Charitably sporadic. I say this all the time, I'm pretty sure, but writing is something that I still am getting back into, and so I consider myself out of practice. I'm terrible at planning ahead for the most part, but hopefully getting up to this sort of nonsense will cure me of that particular malady.

Thanks for reading, I appreciate every kudo and comment and am a chatty ol' flame who will almost always respond to your messages. Y'know, if that's a thing you appreciate. If not, I'm probably going to do it anyway if you comment and I apologise in advance.

Meetings.

Chapter Summary

Meetings are held, feelings are had, and an encounter begins.

Chapter Notes

Hi there! I've been quiet. I'd say I've been busy, but that's not entirely true! Mostly, I've been wrestling with ideas, trying to figure out what works here and what works elsewhere, and generally having a little difficulty with the whole writing thing. You know how it is.

Anyway, I'm very excited to present the thing I've been waiting to do since I got this idea. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra made her way down a series of twisting alleyways, moving silently and quickly until she approached what on first glance appeared to be a pile of discarded building materials leaning against a wall. She pulled a plank aside, revealing an entrance just barely wide enough for her to wriggle through and found herself in a disused portion of the town's underground sewer system. She wandered the labyrinthine passages, her eyes picking up the tell-tale signs left behind before finding herself outside of a circular room with a curtain drawn over the entranceway. She paused, drawing in a deep breath, before walking through.

Inside, another Mandalorian sat at an old, ramshackle desk, reading a fragile-looking scroll of vellum. Her armor was jet black, save for the helmet, which was a dark blue. The arms of her suit were adorned with protective sigils that had been etched into the armor. Were one to look on the back, they would see stylized wings painted on, flanking the housing where the Mandalorian's jetpack would attach. Leaning against the desk was a preposterously large railgun with an imposing spike affixed to the barrel as a crude bayonet. Catra had once seen the Mandalorian

wield this weapon single-handedly and still marveled at the raw strength that the woman's deceptively slight frame held.

"Catra." The seated Mandalorian looked up from her reading to acknowledge Catra's presence.

"Master." Catra nodded.

"Why have you come?" The woman's voice was measured, betraying no emotion.

"I have taken a contract. I wished to inform you." Catra matched the formality of the woman's speech, clasping her hands behind her. There was an almost ritualistic way to things here, and she meant to follow it perfectly, especially considering what she was about to discuss.

"You have taken many contracts since striking out on your own, Catra," the Master replied, waving a hand in dismissal, "and none of them have occasioned a visit." She stood slowly from her seat and walked out from behind the desk. "What makes this contract special?"

"The target," Catra replied, "and… the client."

"A special contract indeed," the Master nodded, "if both sides warrant such praise." She stood in front of Catra, arms folded. "Start with the target."

"The target, according to the Guild, is a Jedi." Catra stared into the Master's helmet with confidence. "I have reviewed what evidence there is and concur. The Guild requested a Mandalorian for this task specifically, given the nature of the request."

"And the request is?"

"To capture this Jedi alive and deliver them to the Empire." Catra resisted the urge to look away. In spite of the fact that both were helmeted, she could feel the Master's eyes on her. It was a profoundly uncomfortable feeling.

“So, your contract is to capture an ancient enemy and deliver them to a younger enemy?” There was a hint of amusement in the Master’s voice. “A bold decision to make, I must say. Yet here you are, seeking what, exactly? Permission? Surely not, for you already took the contract. Reassurance that you made the correct decision, perhaps? It is not our way to provide such a comfort, as you know full well. Then why?” Catra fought the urge to fidget.

“I thought that it would be better to tell you myself than have you find out some other way,” she finally responded. “I know that to work for the Empire could be seen as a betrayal.” Catra paused, looking for some sign from the Master that she understood. “I wanted to tell you that I judged the honor of facing such a foe as a Jedi outweighed any shame that I felt taking a contract from the Imperials.”

“If such was your judgment, who am I to speak against it?” The Master nodded her assent. “You will complete this contract for your honor and the honor of the Clan. You will deliver this Jedi to the Empire, or you will fall in the attempt. A Mandalorian honors any contract taken, regardless of personal feeling or prejudice.” The Master paused before adding, “This is the way.”

“This is the way,” Catra responded in kind before sketching a short bow and turning to leave.

“And Catra?” The Master’s voice stopped her, and she turned around again. “Do come visit again soon. I look forward to hearing of your success.” There was a warmth to her words that made Catra smile beneath her helmet.

“I will, Master.” She stepped through the curtain and was soon gone.

*

“So,” Entrapta began, looking out the cockpit at the vibrant blues and greys of hyperspace, “Why are we leaving the Outer Rim territories?”

“Have to go where the work is, Entrapta,” Catra replied from her position in the pilot’s seat. “At least, when the work is this well-paying.” She leaned back into the chair.

“I’ve noticed that well-paying usually means more dangerous than normal,” Entrapta continued, fidgeting slightly. “And if this job pays well enough for us to enter the Middle Rim, well, then it must be really dangerous!” Catra turned her head to regard the Twi’lek.

“Yeah, this one’s probably more dangerous than most.” She raised an eyebrow, then remembered that Entrapta wouldn’t be able to see it because of the helmet. “Is that going to be a problem for you?”

“Oh, no, I mean, not really.” Entrapta looked at Catra and then back out the cockpit window. “I mean, you’re the one who’s going to be in the most danger; I usually just take care of the ship while you’re away.” She looked down at the instrument panel. “It’s just…”

“Out with it,” Catra commanded. “What’s bothering you about this mission?”

“I’m not really good at this,” Entrapta muttered. She took a deep breath. “I’m not really good at people, and at relationships, and at any of that stuff.” She shrugged. “People always ignored me or tried to make me act more ‘normal’ or whatever, but you,” and she looked at Catra, “You just let me be myself, and nobody else has ever really done that and I just think that, well, you’re my friend.” She crossed her arms as if to hug herself and quietly continued, “I don’t want you to get hurt. I don’t have many friends, so if something bad happens to you, I’d have roughly 100% fewer friends.”

“Oh.” Catra was silent for a few moments, glad that her helmet hid the surprised expression on her face. “Hey, listen, it might be dangerous, but I can handle it.” She reached out slowly and patted Entrapta’s shoulder encouragingly. “I’ll come back from this

one, no problem, and then we'll see what kind of ship upgrades we can get."

"There's no way of actually predicting that, but I appreciate that you are trying to reassure me." Entrapta beamed. "I was right, you *are* my friend." There was a soft beeping from the navi-computer and a warning light on the dash began to blink in an amber rhythm. "Ooh, we're almost there!"

"Yeah, seems so." Catra reached out and pulled back on the throttle, dropping the ship back to subspace speeds. The view shifted from the maelstrom of hyperspace to the looming planet of Takodana. "Huh, doesn't look like much, does it?"

"Most planets don't look like much from this far out," Entrapta replied. The ship began to shudder as it entered the planet's atmosphere. "That's supposed to happen," she continued, not looking at Catra. "Atmosphere here seems a little rough, according to sensors."

"Well, with any luck our arrival will go unnoticed. If this Jedi has made friends with any of the locals, we don't need them getting a heads-up about our arrival." Catra studied the landscape looking for a place to land. "I'd like to avoid any spaceports, if possible."

"Here," Entrapta replied, pointing at a set of coordinates on one of the sensor readouts. "This is close enough to the target's first appearance, but far enough out that we should be able to land with little notice, which isn't saying a whole lot since any ship is going to make a lot of noise."

"Thanks, Entrapta." Catra adjusted course and leaned back in her seat. "You'll stay with the ship, right?"

"Of course! That's what I usually do; there's always something to fix."

"Well, try not to take apart anything important; I might need you to come get me pretty quickly, depending on how things go."

Catra sighed and stood up. "Can you babysit the autopilot? I have to get things ready."

"Sure!" Entrapta slid into the just-vacated seat. "I wonder what kind of improvements I can make to the shipboard AI…"

"Wait until after we've landed, please," Catra called over her shoulder as she left the cockpit.

*

Takodana, it turned out, was a very boring planet for the most part. There was one destination of note, Maz Kanata's castle, but as far as Catra could tell, the rogue Jedi had not made any move toward the castle, instead cutting a haphazard trail from one small community to another. Either she was aware that she was being hunted and wanted to confuse her actual destination to anyone tracking her, or she did not actually know where she was going. Based on the number of fights this Jedi had gotten into already, Catra was pretty sure that it was the latter reason.

In contrast to her quarry, Catra had managed to keep a low profile as she followed in her target's footsteps. The locals were only too willing to gossip about the strange drifter who seemed to get into at least one fight per settlement. The description was usually the same: travel-stained cloak that might have been white at one point in its life, grey tunic, and a face that nobody could ever seem to recall.

"You could tell she was goin' out of her way to hide her face. Kept her hood up, mostly, and stuck to the darker corners of the bar," a portly bartender had told her. "Figured she was runnin' from something, but I never ask a question that I don't want the answer to." He shrugged, polishing a glass. "Lotta folks come through here are running from one thing or another."

Catra had thanked the bartender and continued on her way, moving from settlement to settlement and gradually getting an idea of the target's general pattern. Never seemed to stay in one

place for more than a day or two, most folk never saw her enter or leave town. Opinions on whether she was a Jedi were a fair mix of healthy skepticism and muttered superstition. Well, Catra thought, anyone who had actually seen her fight with a lightsaber had ended up dead, so it made sense that rumors were all that she could find.

On her fourth day, Catra came to the end of her trail. She'd passed through the small village where the Jedi had been accosted by the two Guild hunters and was confident that her target would not have stayed in the place where she'd killed two people. Eventually, Catra found someone who remembered seeing her take the southern road out of the village. Catra took the same road, feeling a slight thrill of excitement. Entrapta had been monitoring the comms traffic in the surrounding area and had not heard of any incidents since they'd landed. Catra was hoping to catch up with the Jedi in the next settlement. It was, by some accounts, a larger settlement than the one she was leaving. Perhaps the Jedi thought to lie low for a bit and wait for things to settle down.

She was almost there.

*

It had been years since Adora had stayed anywhere for more than a handful of days, yet here she was, still staying with Madame Razz and Glimmer after nearly three weeks. It turned out that Razz was true to her word, and nobody ever came looking for her. She still insisted on wearing a mask around others and gave her name as Mara when she helped out around the shop – Razz insisted that she keep busy, warning that an Adora with nothing to do was an Adora who would lose her mind.

"You are running from something, I think," Razz said to her one afternoon, as the two were preparing dinner together. Adora sighed, looking down at the ground.

“Well, the Empire wants to kill me.” She shrugged. “Running seems like a good option.”

“No, no, no,” Razz waved her hand about as if to knock Adora’s response out of the air. “The Empire, they might chase, but they are easily avoided.” She looked Adora straight in the eyes. “What you’re running from, it is not so easy to give the slip.”

“What are you talking about?” Adora stared back in confusion. “The only thing chasing me is the Empire.”

“Pah! Did Mara teach you nothing? Perhaps you slept through your lessons one day, hmm?” Razz shook her head. “Sometimes the thing you are running from is not chasing you, it just *is*.”

“What do you know about Mara?” Adora’s voice came out like a growl, her eyes narrowed.

“Ah, Adora. Too quick to anger, my child. Madame Razz knows all about Mara. Mara is an old friend.” She smiled. “Mara is always very proud of her apprentice, you know.”

“Mara…” Adora swallowed hard. “Madame Razz, Mara is—”

“I know, dear, I know.” Razz’s smile dropped for a moment. “I felt it.” She brightened up again. “But you are here now, so perhaps Mara knew what she was doing, eh?”

“She tried to give me time to run but I couldn’t—I went back, and then I saw, and I—” Adora’s words came out in a rush and she fell down to her hands and knees. “I couldn’t save her,” she whispered. “I couldn’t save her, and then I lost control and I—oh no, Catra, I…”

“Shh, Adora, it is all right.” Razz knelt down and gently embraced Adora. “You have stopped running now, yes?”

“I’m supposed to control my emotions,” Adora moaned. “This isn’t right.”

“Pah, Jedi nonsense,” Razz harumphed. “Locked away in their towers, removed from everything. It is no wonder they fell.” Adora stiffened at her words, but Razz continued, “They were a long way from where they started, and my Mara knew. She was such a smart one; they should have listened to her more!” She tucked a finger under Adora’s chin and lifted, so the two were face-to-face again. “You, Adora, you have choices to make.”

“But I don’t even know where to start,” Adora responded. “I’ve just been… surviving.”

“Surviving is a good start,” Razz said with a nod, “but surviving is not enough.” She tapped a finger to Adora’s chest. “You have to want more than survival. Why does Adora survive, hm? What good is Adora alive?” She stood up. “What does Adora *want*, that is the most important question.” She took Adora’s hand and pulled, bringing Adora back to her feet.

“I… what do I want? I don’t know.”

“Hah, perhaps you think so, but I think you know. You just forgot, is all.” Madame Razz wiped her hands on her apron. “Now go on, go wash your face and get your mask. You have an appointment to keep.”

“What is this appointment you keep talking about?” Adora asked, curiously. “You never told me.”

“Well, even Madame Razz can only keep you hidden for so long,” Razz replied with a careless shrug. “Someone has come looking, and it is time for them to find you.” She shooed Adora towards the washroom. “Go, go, hurry. Your hunter will be here soon, and I would rather you meet outside than in. My shop is messy enough as it is.”

“My hunter?” Adora called from the washroom. “Another bounty hunter, you mean?”

“Ah, yes, but this one is special.” Razz returned to preparing dinner, chopping vegetables and dropping them into a merrily

bubbling pot. “This one will catch you.”

“We’ll see about that,” Adora replied, hooking her lightsaber to her belt and pulling up her mask. She donned her cloak and pulled the hood over her head. “Anything you can tell me about this hunter?”

“Nothing that you do not already know,” Razz replied, “but maybe you forgot.”

“Great,” Adora muttered, heading for the shop entrance.

“Have fun, dearie!” Razz turned back to her cooking, muttering to herself. “I hope I have enough, they will be so hungry after all that exercise.”

*

The longer Catra wandered up and down the roads of the village, the more convinced she became that *something* was there. She stopped in front of a row of shops and looked from one to the next. Grocer, mechanic, ------, and general supply store. Catra paused and shook her head. Something wasn’t right here. She tried looking again: grocer, mechanic, ------, and supplies.

Something was missing, she just couldn’t tell what. Okay, she thought, one more time: Grocer, mechanic, cloaked figure, and supplies. Wait. Shit. Her hand flew to her side and her blaster cleared its holster in record time. The figure, who Catra now realized was wearing a mask as well as a hooded cloak, was looking directly at her.

“I suppose you’re the one looking for me,” the figure said. The voice was distorted by the mask, but decidedly feminine. Something itched at the back of Catra’s mind, but she pushed it down, focusing on the figure in front of her.

“That’s right,” Catra responded evenly, playing the cool and collected hunter. “You’re a hard girl to find.”

*

A Mandalorian? Adora managed to keep her expression neutral but was surprised. From what she could recall, Mandalorians didn't leave the Outer Rim if they could help it.

"I prefer it that way," she responded evenly. "Don't suppose you're just here to chat."

The Mandalorian gave a wry chuckle. "Afraid not. You've got some people real interested in meeting you, and they asked me to make it happen." The voice was cool, collected, and maddeningly familiar. Adora ignored it.

"Not really into meeting new people right now," Adora replied. If this hunter was going to play it casual, then so was she. "You'll have to disappoint them, I'm afraid."

"Yeah, that's not gonna work for me," the Mandalorian responded, shifting her stance to better aim her blaster pistol. "Any chance of you coming quietly? I'm supposed to bring you in alive, but that's kind of a spectrum, y'know?"

Adora resisted the urge to roll her eyes. Who *was* this asshole? She breathed out slowly and let her mind drift, relaxing visibly.

*

"You know that isn't going to happen," the masked figure responded. Catra shrugged.

"Well, it was worth a shot," she said, and fired her blaster. There was a flash of golden light and her blaster bolt deflected straight up into the air. The figure had moved impossibly fast, and now stood in a fighting stance, cloak fluttering to the ground, a golden lightsaber blade in one hand. *Blonde hair, huh? Seems familiar,* Catra's mind opined. "So, you *are* the Jedi," she said instead.

"And you're the bounty hunter," the Jedi replied. "Glad we're on the same page." Her voice took on a hard edge, recognizable even

through the mask's filter. "This is your last chance to leave quietly."

"And this is *your* last chance to come with me while you can still walk," Catra shot back. Who *was* this asshole?

"So be it," the Jedi stated. She dashed forward, and things began to happen.

Chapter End Notes

Ha ha, CLIFFHANGER. I'll try to get the next update out sooner rather than later, because I maybe do feel just a *little* bad about it. Not a whole lot though; the more I kept writing to get to the fight, the more other things kept popping up along the way, and eventually things just got to be long enough that I decided to just stop at the most inopportune point and bring y'all some good fightin' next time. Maybe some history, too!

Look, I got a neat idea about how to do the fight and it needs its own chapter to work properly, okay? Please forgive an old bonfire his amusements.

Thanks for reading! I can't believe people were still finding this and leaving kudos while I was bangin' away at this new chapter. I really do appreciate every single one of you. If you want to excoriate me for leaving you hanging, leave a comment. I read 'em all!

Apotheosis

Chapter Summary

A shared history and a fierce good fight.

Chapter Notes

Kept you waiting, huh?

Some of what's down there might be uh... intense? It felt intense to write. Nothing too terrible, I think, but here's a heads-up just in case.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's parents were having an argument. They had put her to bed, and then she had heard the sound of the front door sliding open and closed as they'd exited to discuss things outside, somewhere that Catra couldn't hear – in theory. In truth, she had slipped out of bed and quietly followed them to listen by the open window.

"C'yra, we cannot just leave our home, it's not that simple!" Her father sounded exhausted; Catra had a feeling that this was not the first time they'd had this conversation.

"I know it's not simple, but we can face whatever complexities there might be better than we can face a war!" Her mother's voice was strong and certain, but Catra heard an undercurrent of something else there as well, something unfamiliar. Fear, perhaps?

"The war is not here, my love," Her father's voice was reassuring, quiet. "We are safe here."

"For how long, Finn?" Catra could hear her mother pacing back and forth. "It was bad enough when it was just the Separatists in the Outer Rim, but now they're saying that the Jedi have turned on the Senate, on the Chancellor himself!"

"Hah!" Her father snorted. "Propaganda and lies. I know the Jedi; I know they would not do such a thing."

"Lies or truth, dear, it does not matter if a garrison of clones land here and start tearing the place apart looking for separatists or Jedi or goodness knows what else." Her mother was sounding increasingly agitated. "War will come here no matter what the truth may be."

"If it is such an inevitability, then why should we flee?" Her father sighed. "Whatever comes, we will face it together. We will get through it, together." Catra heard her father's footsteps approach her mother, heard a rustling of fabric as he embraced her. "No matter what."

"I know," her mother replied, voice slightly muffled as she spoke into Finn's chest. "I worry for our daughter, love. I fear for her."

"And I do as well, C'yra, but I will protect her from all harm." Another sigh, this time slightly more contented and less frustrated. "Tomorrow, I'll start building us a shelter. Secret, well-stocked. If the war does come here, we will survive it." Catra made a face as she heard her parents kissing. Gross.

"I hope you are right, my love. I truly do."

He was not.

*

Catra's jetpack ignited and threw her backwards, narrowly avoiding an exploratory horizontal slice from the Jedi's lightsaber. She fired a couple of times with her pistol as she cannoned through the air, hoping to at least give the Jedi something to think about. The Jedi deflected the bolts with what Catra considered to be not nearly enough effort, but it bought her enough time to bring her wrist-mounted launcher around and fire a small rocket at the Jedi's feet. The Jedi appeared to be caught off guard by this maneuver and was launched backwards by the explosion into the wall of the nearest building. Catra gave a tight grin of

satisfaction as she watched the Jedi's head bounce off of the wall. That ought to slow her down a little.

*

Adora was practicing her meditation when she heard the sound of an explosion, followed by blaster fire. Her eyes snapped open, and she looked towards the door of the small quarters that she shared with her master, Mara. The two had been sent to one of the border worlds, right on the edge of the Middle Rim, to oversee rebuilding efforts on a newly liberated planet. A chance for Mara to show her young padawan the less violent aspects of Jedi responsibilities in wartime, so they had been told at the time, but Adora suspected that Mara had done something to upset the Council again. They'd been sent with a single squad of clone troopers, "just in case." At the moment, Adora was of the opinion that perhaps they should have brought more than one squad. The communicator on her wrist began to blink and beep, demanding attention.

"—dora? Adora!" Mara's voice came through the small speaker, tinny and distorted. "Adora, if you're there, respond!"

"Master? What's going on?" Adora's voice carried a hint of concern. Concern, not fear, because fear was not something that a Jedi was supposed to feel, along with all kinds of other emotions. Yep, Adora was definitely just concerned and not afraid.

"No time to explain, where are you right now?" It sounded almost like Mara was in the middle of a running gun-battle, which did nothing to lessen Adora's level of anxiety.

"I'm still in our room, I'll come to you!" Adora was already on her feet, buckling her belt and reaching for her lightsaber.

"No!" Mara's voice carried a tone that brooked no argument and froze Adora mid-buckle. "Stay right where you are. I'll be there soon. Do not ---st the c----" There was the sound of another explosion.

"Master? Master? Mara!" The communicator went silent. Adora absolutely did not panic. She stayed where she was, finished buckling on her belt and gripped her lightsaber hilt in her hand – and maybe concentrated just a little on slowing down her breathing. The door snapped open. "Master?"

Standing in the doorway was one of the clones, helmet on. "Trooper, what's going on?" Adora asked. In response, the trooper raised his blaster rifle. "Wh—" Adora scrambled to ignite her lightsaber in time, but she already knew she was going to be too late; the trooper was going to shoot her before she could block it and—

"Ugh." The trooper gave a grunt as a blue glow blossomed from the center of his chest and traveled upwards, neatly bisecting his neck and head. He toppled over, quite definitively dead, revealing the form of Mara behind him. Adora, who had mostly seen the effects that lightsabers could have on the droid troops used by the separatists and definitely not on humanoid organics, felt queasy. Mara was covered in soot, possibly blood, and tattered clothing.

"Come, Adora." She motioned for Adora to follow. "We have to go."

"But—what—that—who—why—WHAT." Adora managed to get out. A look of sympathy crossed Mara's face before it fell back into a stoic mask.

"Child, I promise I will tell you everything when there is time but right now, there isn't. All you need to know is that we have to run." She held out her hand, Adora took it, and they ran.

*

Adora shook her head to clear it as she levered herself back to her feet. She had to admit, the Mandalorian was resourceful and much quicker than the usual thugs. The bounty hunter moved with a feline grace that Adora would have admired if she wasn't the target of the hunter's aggressions. Adora flipped her

lightsaber around, blade pointing back down her arm and deflected another few exploratory shots from the Mandalorian before sprinting towards her. She pulled up short in front of the hunter and pirouetted, swinging horizontally at the helmet, and was momentarily surprised when the lightsaber did not slice through it. *Oh, right. Beskar,* Adora thought, *maybe don't aim for the armor next time.* The force of Adora's blow, however, was not wasted. The Mandalorian's head snapped to one side, and she stumbled, body following the path her head had charted. Adora dropped and swept her leg around in a clean sweep, knocking the Mandalorian on to her side.

*

Catra was bored as only a young teenager could be. There might be turmoil, war, and death in the greater galaxy, but as far as she was concerned, there was no war beyond arguing with her dad about learning how to ride a speeder bike and convincing her mother that yes, she was old enough to stay out on her own beyond sundown. Much of their community had left, fearing the war encroaching on the local star system, but Catra's father had kept them there, kept them safe just as he had promised. Catra was grateful that she got to stay, certainly, but most of the other children her age had disappeared along with their families, and she could only take hanging out with her parents for so long before it would drive her mad. She spent an increasing amount of time sitting on the roof of her home, staring up at the stars and trying to will something interesting into happening.

To say, then, that Catra was elated at the sudden appearance of a mysterious stranger and her teenage companion taking up residence in the house across the street would have been an understatement. She immediately began pestering her parents with questions about the new arrivals and was surprised when both her father and mother seemed to know the woman. "An old friend," her father had told her, "Who had to flee her home because of the war."

"And the girl? Is that her daughter?" Catra had asked.

"No, I don't think so," her mother replied. "She was orphaned by the war, and Mara took her in."

"Wow," Catra considered what it might be like to lose her parents and frowned. "That sounds awful."

"You know," her father shot a look to her mother, who nodded. "We were going to go over later to help Mara settle in; I'm sure that you could show the young lady around while we're busy."

Catra perked up at this suggestion. "Can I?"

"Absolutely," her mother said with a smile.

*

Okay, so perhaps taking a lightsaber swing to the head wasn't the most tactical way of dealing with the Jedi, but Catra hadn't expected the ethereal blade to have so much force behind it. She rolled as she hit the ground, feeling more than seeing the follow-up swing from the Jedi carve a furrow in the ground where her torso had been a moment before. Catra needed to even the odds, quickly, or she was at the very least going to be replacing more equipment than this job was probably worth, if not her own limbs. She shot a brief spray of flame from her wrist-mounted flamethrower and was rewarded with the sight of the Jedi's leg wrapping coming aflame. Catra scrambled to her feet, running through the various non-lethal options left to her. She settled for shooting a strong, thin cable from another wrist-mounted gadget and gave a grunt of satisfaction as it twisted around the Jedi's midsection, pinning her arms to her sides.

*

Adora had a problem. She was fairly sure that she was actively breaking the Jedi code. At least, she assumed that she was. The Jedi Order had a real thing about forming attachments, and Adora was, at this very moment, feeling incredibly Attached to the cute girl who lived across the street from where she and Mara had moved. Adora had tried hard to not become attached, but the girl

had these beautiful, mismatched eyes – one gold, one blue – and this smirk that made Adora's knees weak and a squeaky, raspy laugh when she found something funny that made Adora's stomach get all fluttery and, well, one gets the idea.

But according to the Jedi Code – for whatever it was worth, with the bulk of the Order massacred and whatever remnants existed being hunted across the galaxy – Adora, as a proper Jedi, should not be feeling these sorts of things. She was not supposed to want anything or anyone. She had been pledged to the Jedi Order as a young child and knew no other life. It was out of her hands, and yet… she couldn't shake the feelings that bubbled up inside her and swirled around. She had a friend! She had a friend that she lo—cared about, and if one were to ask one of the elders or put the question to the Jedi Council, that was a weakness. Unfortunately for Adora, the Jedi Council were permanently unavailable, so they were not there to provide the proper structure that would help her divest of these feelings. Mara, though… Mara was there. And Adora was still Mara's apprentice, Mara still spent time teaching Adora how to fight, how to use the Force for good, and most importantly these days, how to hide. So, Adora asked her about it.

"A friend, you say?" Mara raised an eyebrow.

"The girl across the street, you know her," Adora replied hurriedly. "She—we've been spending time together. She shows me around, and we talk about stuff, and sometimes we race and sometimes we spar and sometimes we just kind of sit around and do nothing and—"

"Adora," Mara interrupted. "You're rambling." She gave a small smile. "And it hasn't interfered with your studies, and I certainly don't need you around all the time. What is the problem?" Her smile grew slightly wider as she watched Adora's face begin to turn pink.

"Well," Adora began, "she's important to me." She frowned. That didn't convey what she was feeling at all. She tried again. "She's

really important to me. And… I think I've gotten too attached."

"Attached?" Mara's eyebrow arched again. "And you're worried about getting attached to her?"

"Well, isn't it against the Code?" Adora asked. "Attachment is dangerous for a Jedi, right?"

"Oh, my young apprentice," Mara laughed, startling Adora. "My dear Adora, these days simply existing is dangerous for a Jedi." She shook her head, her face becoming serious. "Adora, you are alive because I fought to get to you in time, and I promise you that if I did not care for you as deeply as I do, I would not have been able to do what I did."

"But—"

"Adora." Mara cut her off with a tone that brooked no argument. "Your attachment to this girl is far less dangerous than the clone army, or the bounty hunters, or goodness knows what else the Empire has sent after us." She cracked a small smile and continued, "I'd bet she's far more interesting, too."

"Well," Adora's blush intensified to a truly incandescent level, "I think so." She shook her head. "I still don't understand, Master. The Code states—"

"The Code is not all there is to being a Jedi," Mara replied. "At some point, you have to think for yourself, and let go of the Code."

"Let go?" Adora was shocked. This had never come up in her training.

"Yes, Adora. Let go. Even a Jedi deserves happiness, and joy is something that has been in short supply since, well." She sighed. "No need to get into that again." Mara smiled at her apprentice. "Let go, Adora." She waved her hands. "Shoo! Off with you! Go find your friend, tell her that you care!" She hustled Adora out the door. "Don't wait until you can't," she whispered to herself.

*

"Seriously?" Adora grunted as she twisted her arms, severing the cable with her lightsaber. "What was that supposed to accomplish, exactly?"

"This," the Mandalorian replied, tossing what looked like a thermal detonator at Adora's feet. Instead of a conventional explosion, however, it sprayed what looked to be fire suppressant foam all over Adora, who pulled a face under her mask.

"Lame," she opined, taking a step towards the Mandalorian – only she didn't actually take a step. With a creeping horror, Adora realized that the foam was hardening, freezing her in place.

"I dunno, my friend worked very hard on that," the Mandalorian replied, approaching as the foam continued to bind and expand, engulfing Adora's legs, creeping up her torso and restraining her arms. Adora tried not to panic as she felt the foam creep up the back of her neck and onto her head. "Sweet dreams, Jedi."

No, Adora thought as the foam crept over her mask and began to obscure her vision. *No, no, no, no, not like this, I can't get caught, I can't go back, I can't…* There was a whisper in the back of her head, a whisper that she had spent years ignoring that was slowly growing into a feral snarl, a snarl that said, "Then don't."

*

Catra leaned against the doorframe, doing her best to look incredibly cool as she watched her friend make her way across the street. She gave a lazy smile and a "hey, Adora," secretly enjoying the way that the girl's face flushed at the sound. "What's up?"

"Hey, Catra," Adora said. "Can I talk to you?"

Something in Adora's tone made Catra's ears perk up. Adora sounded nervous, and in Catra's experience Adora was never nervous. "Y'know, I don't think I have anything else going on at the moment," she grinned. Adora laughed, and Catra briefly

considered the fact that she could get used to hearing that laugh every day for the rest of her life.

"You're such a jerk," Adora replied, sticking out her tongue. "But uh," she continued, the nervousness in her voice surging back, "seriously, can we maybe go somewhere that isn't right in front of your house?"

"Yeah, sure," Catra nodded. "C'mon, I know a place." The two walked in silence that was a heady combination of comfort and awkwardness until they reached a dingy-looking alley. "In here," Catra motioned, leading Adora by the hand – and trying not to blush at the contact – into a little ramshackle lean-to constructed out of scrap metal. "How's this for privacy?" She turned to look at Adora and was met by those piercing blue eyes that stared back into hers, like they could see right into her mind and that would definitely have taken her breath away if she weren't so incredibly cool. Catra desperately attempted to look anywhere else, and her eyes fell on Adora's lips instead, which oh great, that's way less distracting, great job Catra.

"Um, it's fine, yeah," Adora muttered, breaking eye contact.

"So!" Catra said with a forced casualness, trying to maintain her composure. "What's up, Adora?"

"Oh! Um." Adora fidgeted, clearly nervous. "I was talking to my m—to Mara earlier, about some… things… and she kind of, I guess, helped me figure some stuff out." She fell quiet for a few moments.

"And?" Catra asked, suddenly feeling very warm. Why was her heart beating faster? You are absolutely gay for this girl*, her mind supplied helpfully. Adora was staring resolutely at the wall, but her hand reached out hesitantly for Catra's. Catra, because she was such a good friend, took Adora's hand.*

"I realized that I… I mean, that you…" Adora was floundering. Catra hesitantly reached out and put her other hand on Adora's

shoulder.

"Hey, Adora, whatever it is, it's fine, okay? You don't have to tell me if you don't want to."

"No," Adora turned, and Catra once again found herself staring into those eyes. "No, I need to tell you that, Catra…" She trailed off.

"Yeah?" Catra suddenly realized that she had been moving closer to Adora.

"That…" Adora's voice dropped to a whisper as she began to lean into Catra as well, their noses practically touching, "I think I'm in…" she managed.

It was about that time that the two of them heard the explosion.

*

"Well," Catra said to herself, watching the masked Jedi disappear under a layer of hardening foam, "that was easier than expected." She approached the humanoid-shaped mound of foam and walked a careful perimeter around it. The Jedi certainly appeared to be incapacitated, but now Catra realized that she didn't have the slightest clue how she was going to get her back to *Darla*. She thumbed her communicator. "Entrapta, what would you say the best way to move uh, a statue that used to be a Jedi to the ship."

"Well," Entrapta's voice came over, slightly tinny. "Since I know what you took with you, and I know it didn't include any sort of conveyance, I'd say probably the best way would be for me to fly the ship to you."

"Huh, right," Catra frowned. Why hadn't she thought of that? "Well, I'll send you the coordinates and you… can…" she trailed off.

"Catra? Catra, are you going to send the coordinates?" Entrapta's voice chirped. Catra didn't hear it, however, because she was too

busy staring at what should be an immobile lump of hardened foam shaking and creaking as it suddenly detonated outward. Chunks of foam bounced off of Catra's armor and she saw the Jedi, now unmasked, standing in the epicenter. Her blonde hair was whipping about wildly, her blue eyes were blazing with a dangerous fire and fixed upon Catra, who for perhaps the first time in her professional career, was entirely, utterly, caught off guard.

"Holy shit, Ado—hrrk!" Catra's hands flew to her throat as she felt it constrict, saw Adora's face twist into a snarl as she raised one hand. Catra felt her feet leave the ground, suspended by an unseen force as her throat grew tighter. "Hnngk, Ado…"

Seemingly in response, Adora raised her other hand and Catra suddenly felt a pressure on her helmet, as if some giant hand was trying to crush it. Her breathing troubles forgotten for the moment, Catra now scrambled to remove her helmet, hands fumbling as she felt the helmet begin to tighten around her skull. "Ad.. 's… me…" she managed, as she felt herself lifted higher. Catra managed to rip the helmet off of her head right as she felt herself launched into a wall. Her head bounced off the unyielding concrete and she knew no more.

*

"Adora, you have to run." The voice of Mara is calm, even in the face of her own death.

"Master, no! I can't leave you!" Adora is confused, defiant.

"Adora, what's going on?" Catra, nervous.

"CATRA, RUN!" Adora has to protect her.

"Pathetic." A cold, harsh voice, steeped in darkness.

"Let her go!" Mara's tone is steel, harsh.

"M—mom? Dad?" Catra, bordering on tears, disbelieving.

"Master!" Adora, desperate.

"You've lost, and now you are mine." The cold voice again, amused at her pain.

And then, a primal scream, from the very depths of her soul. A surge of uncontrollable power. Bodies, broken and smoking. And Catra's one of them.

*

Adora was sprinting towards the prone body of the Mandalorian, Catra. She fell to her knees, hands outstretched, feeling for a pulse, eyes searching for any sign of life. "Catra, no, don't you dare, don't you *fucking* dare," she muttered, desperation and shame battering at whatever sense of calm that she was clinging to as the adrenaline of the fight drained out of her. She had broken her one rule, in a moment of weakness and fear. She had reached out for the Force and found it more than willing to respond, and she had lost control, again.

She had killed Catra, again.

"Adora!" Madame Razz's voice echoed in her mind. "It is time to stop running from yourself, Adora. It is time to stop pretending."

"I killed her, Razz, I killed her!" Adora cradled Catra's head, feeling the sticky warmth of blood leaking from the back of her head.

"Did you? Can you trust your senses, Adora?" Madame Razz gently chided. "Open your eyes, Adora. What do you see? I see a problem that you can solve, Adora."

"I can't," Adora argued. "I can't control it. I can't reach out again."

"You can!" Razz shot back. "You are not perfect, true, but you can do this thing."

"What if I fail, or—or—what if I make it worse? What if I've lost her again?"

“She did not travel through the vastness of space to die here, silly girl. Trust the Force, Adora. Save the cat.”

Adora felt it, the same presence she had felt when she first entered Madame Razz’s shop. A quiet, ancient strength that wrapped itself around her and calmed her mind. She closed her eyes, steadied her breathing, and opened them again. Her eyes blazed, not with anger, or rage, but with a soft blue light. Her hands hovered over Catra’s head, and the bleeding slowed. She now could see the slow rise and fall of Catra’s chest, the slight fluttering of her eyelids. Adora held her close and waited, eyes still shimmering.

“Mmh,” Catra muttered as she slowly opened her eyes. She found herself staring into the bright blue eyes that had haunted her for years, a serene smile that looked so different from the twisted face of rage that she had seen just moments before.

“Catra?” Adora asked, hesitant. Catra smiled, weakly.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

Oh gosh. I don't even know where to begin here, other than to say uh... I hope this was worth waiting for? I've been off doing other things, trying to write some things for other fandoms (Owl House fandom, how we doin'?) and generally feeling sort of like I'd neglected this, the first story that I wrote that really *clicked*, y'know? It was hard to come back to!

But I had to, didn't I? Couldn't just leave it on a cliffhanger, not before I took a run at doing this chapter in a whole time-skipping, perspective-swapping mess. I don't know how well it turned out, or if I even like what's there right now. I might go back later and rework some of the rougher bits, but bless the Titans, Frogs, and Demon Prince, I had to get this out into the world now or it'd never happen.

I've ended the story, for now. I'll come back to it at some point, but this feels like as good a place to stop for what we'll think of as Season One or something. I hadn't planned beyond this sort of climactic reunion, so I have to give some thought as to what comes next, and for that I have to actually focus, and right now my focus is decidedly Elsewhere. I dunno, serialized storytelling is not my forte (mostly because that would require a schedule, and the only person better at sticking to schedules than me is, like, Patrick Rothfuss).

I will say this, though: I started rewatching She-Ra, and boy I forgot how hard some of those Season 1 episodes go! That first Mystacor episode, with Castaspella being just The Most and some surprisingly hard-hitting discussion about Adora's abusive upbringing? DAMN. Who knows, I might come back to this fic sooner rather than later.

Thanks for reading, so far. This isn't the end, not really, but I'm going to pretend it is so that I take the self-imposed pressure off of myself. Go read my other stuff, I've been writing about Eda fighting the Evil Dead with a certain skeleton and honestly it rules.

End Notes

This is the end, for now. It's kind of a moving goalpost, I like to keep myself on my toes. Can't promise any kind of consistent updates, or even if there will be updates. This was just.. real stuck in my head, couldn't get rid of it. So here we are.

narrows eyes Huh. Kinda cool, I think.

Hey, did you like this? Did I mess something up? Is this the exact nonsense you were looking for? Leave a comment and I will absolutely reply, because I can't help myself.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!